Beacon — Rules (draft v0.1)

Output of the `bg-developer` stage. Written teach-in-play-order per `knowledge/process-and-playtesting.md`. Blind-test this rulebook, not just the game.

The story

Two lighthouse keepers, one treacherous coast. Across **three nights** you read the fog, work the **Tide**, and guide the richest ships into **your** harbour. Most valuable harbour after the third night wins.

Components

- **24 Ship cards** — three suits (Cargo, ☺ Passenger, ⚔ Naval), values **1–4** (two of each per suit).
- **2 sets of 6 Signal cards** (values **0–5**) — one set each.
- **Tide track** (7 spaces) + **1 Tide marker**.
- **First-Keeper token**.

Goal

Score the most **Victory Points** after 3 Nights, from the ships in your Harbour, set bonuses, and Tide bonuses.

Setup

1. Shuffle the 24 Ships; deal three face-down **Night decks** of 8.
2. Put the **Tide marker** on the centre space.
3. Each player takes a **set of 6 Signals** to hand.
4. Give the **First-Keeper token** to whoever last saw the sea (or randomly).

Playing a Night (do this three times)

1. **Reveal** the top 2 ships of this Night's deck to the **Channel**.
2. Play **4 rounds**: a. Both keepers secretly pick **one Signal** and reveal together. b. **Higher value wins the beam:** move the **Tide one space toward you**. **But your opponent (who showed the dimmer light) picks a Channel ship first** — a dim light snatches the cargo in front of it while your bright beam steers the Tide. You take the ship they leave. *Tie:* the Tide stays; the **First Keeper** chooses first, then the other. c. Set spent Signals aside. **Refill** the Channel back to 2 from this Night's deck. (You will commit 4 of your 6 Signals this Night and hold 2 back.)
3. **End of Night:** - **Tide bonus:** whoever's side the Tide is on scores **2 points per space from centre** (up to 6; centre = nobody). The harder you pushed the Tide, the bigger the payoff. - Return the Tide marker to **centre**; take all your Signals back to hand. - **The tide turns:** the keeper who **lost the Tide** (fewest ships if centred) takes the **First-Keeper token** for the next Night.

Game end & scoring

After the third Night, total up: - **Ship values** in your Harbour. - **Convoy bonus:** +2 for each {Cargo + Passenger + Naval} set. - **Run bonus:** +2 for each run of 3 consecutive values in one suit. - **Tide bonuses** earned during play.

Most VP wins. Tie → most **Naval** ships; still tied → shared victory.

FAQ (kept short — if a question recurs, we fix the rule instead)

- **Are our hands open?** Yes. Played Signals stay face-up, so you both know which Signals remain — only the Signal you commit *this* round is secret until the reveal.
- **We played the same Signal — now what?** It's a tie: the Tide doesn't move, and the **First Keeper** picks a ship first. You each still take one of the two.
- **Why does the *dimmer* light grab the ship?** Your bright beam is busy steering the Tide; the keeper who held their light back is free to guide the nearer ship into port. Bright = position, dim = cargo.
- **Who's First Keeper on the first Night?** Whoever last saw the sea (or decide randomly).

Optional module — Fog (push-your-luck)

When revealing the Channel, place the top ship **face-down**. The beam winner may take it **sight unseen** before the face-up one. *Adds a gamble; test after the base game feels right.*

Player aid (quick reference)

> *Reveal 2 → both commit a Signal →* ***higher = Tide step toward you; lower picks a ship first*** *→ refill → ×4 rounds → Night end: Tide side scores 2×spaces-from-centre, reset, loser becomes First Keeper. After Night 3: score ships + convoys + runs + Tide.*